Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Topic 5.1 Guided Notes: Introduction to Health Psychology

Unit 5: Mental and Physical Health | AP Psychology

Directions: Read through the topic overview page below and fill in each blank as you go. Use the tables and activities to check your understanding, then head to the quiz link at the end to test yourself.

Source page: appsychreviewhub.com/overviews/topic5.1

Word Bank

Adverse Childhood Experiences	*Problem-Focused Coping*	*Distress*
Resistance Stage	*Eustress*	*Alarm Stage*
Emotion-Focused Coping	*Hypertension*	*Stress*
Immune Suppression	*Health Psychology*	*General Adaptation Syndrome*
Exhaustion Stage	*Stressors*	*Tend and Befriend Theory*
Fight Flight Freeze Response		

1. The Nature of Stress

_____ is the branch of psychology that explores factors that help people lead mentally and physically healthy lives. By exploring how biological, psychological, and sociocultural factors influence health and illness, this unit presents an opportunity to see the real-world application of course content to authentic experiences of wellness.

_____ is the physiological and psychological response to demands or challenges that threaten or exceed an individual's ability to cope. The events, situations, or stimuli that trigger this response are known as _____.

Stressors can be viewed in two distinct ways:

- _____: A positive form of stress that can be motivating, enhancing performance or overall well-being. (e.g., The nervous excitement and adrenaline before a big performance that actually helps you focus.)
- _____: A debilitating, negative form of stress resulting from overwhelming demands that impair functioning. (e.g., The paralyzing anxiety of being severely underprepared for a major AP exam.)

Sources of Stress: Stressors can be experienced as major traumatic events or as daily hassles that steadily build up over time. Furthermore, _____ (ACEs) are potentially traumatic events during childhood (such as abuse, neglect, or household dysfunction) that act as significant sources of stress and can affect a person throughout their entire lifespan.

Apply It: Which Stress Concept?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A looming deadline, a loud argument next door, and a flat tire are all examples of the events and situations that set off a stress response.	

#	Scenario	Concept
2	A chess player feels an exciting rush of pressure during a tournament that keeps her alert and helps her find her best moves.	
3	A student with five overdue assignments feels so overwhelmed that he can't concentrate and stops attending class.	
4	A man who endured years of neglect and a chaotic home as a child still struggles with the effects of that stress as an adult.	

2. Stress and Physical Health

Our mental state has a profound and measurable impact on our physical bodies. Stress is a major factor in heightened susceptibility to disorders and disease.

- _____: Stress has been directly linked to chronically elevated blood pressure, significantly increasing the risk of cardiovascular disease and heart attacks.
- _____: Chronic stress causes a reduction in the activity or effectiveness of the immune system. This makes the body much more vulnerable to illness and infection, which explains why students frequently get a cold right after a highly stressful finals week.

Additionally, prolonged stress is a common culprit behind other physiological issues such as severe tension headaches.

Apply It: Stress and the Body

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A student who spent years caring for a sick parent now has doctor-measured blood pressure well above the normal range.	
2	A nurse working double shifts for weeks keeps catching one infection after another as her body's defenses weaken.	

3. Reactions to Stress

When we encounter stressful situations, our bodies react in deeply ingrained, predictable patterns. Psychologists have identified multiple ways human beings biologically and socially react to stressors.

- _____: Developed by Hans Selye, this three-stage pattern describes the physiological process of experiencing stress. The three stages are:
- _____: Initially, the body's first reaction occurs when the stress is encountered. The body recognizes the stressor and activates the _____, an involuntary physiological reaction to a perceived threat.
- _____: Then, a coping phase occurs as the stress is confronted. The body adapts to the stressor and continues to cope while remaining physiologically activated and on high alert.
- _____: Finally, a depletion phase occurs when the stress subsides, or the body's resources are completely spent. It is during this final phase that the greatest susceptibility to illness occurs because the body is entirely depleted.

- _____: Not all stress responses are strictly fight-or-flight. This theory proposes that some people react to stress by tending to their own needs or the needs of others and actively seeking connection. This phenomenon of nurturing and bonding seems to occur mostly in women.

Graph note: On the graph of Selye's model, resistance to stress first drops briefly before the body mobilizes its resources. Then the body adapts, and resistance to stress peaks. Finally, prolonged stress depletes the body's resources, and resistance sharply declines.

Apply It: Which Stress Reaction?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A child hears a loud crash and instantly freezes in place, unable to move, as his body reacts automatically to the perceived threat.	
2	Right after learning she has been called to the principal's office, a student's body first registers the stressor and begins to mobilize, before it has had any time to adapt.	
3	Three weeks into caring for a newborn on very little sleep, a father keeps up with his duties but stays tense, alert, and physiologically revved up.	
4	After months of relentless stress with no break, a woman's body is worn out, and she falls ill again and again.	
5	After layoffs hit her workplace, a coworker organizes a group meal and checks in on each colleague, responding to the stress by caring for others and connecting.	
6	A psychologist describes the three phases the body moves through under prolonged stress: first reacting, then adapting, then wearing down.	

4. Coping Strategies

When dealing with unavoidable stressors, individuals utilize different strategies to manage their emotional and physical well-being. Coping mechanisms generally fall into two broad categories.

- _____: This strategy involves seeing stress as a problem to be solved and actively working until a solution is found. It involves directly addressing or changing the source of the stress to reduce its impact. (e.g., If you are stressed about failing a math class, you hire a tutor, create a rigid study schedule, and do extra practice problems to fix the grade.)
- _____: This strategy involves managing the emotional reactions to stress as a means of coping, rather than trying to change the stressor itself. Strategies may include deep breathing, meditation, or taking medication aimed at reducing stressful emotional responses. (e.g., If you are stressed about an unavoidable two-hour flight delay at the airport, you put on headphones and listen to a calming playlist to manage your frustration, since you cannot change the flight's schedule.)

Apply It: Which Coping Strategy?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A student stressed about a messy group project emails his teammates, assigns each person a task, and sets a firm schedule to get it done.	
2	Waiting for medical test results that no one can speed up, a woman uses meditation to calm her racing mind.	
3	A man stressed about mounting credit card debt makes a strict budget and takes on extra work to pay it off.	

5. Don't Trip Up! (Common Misconceptions)

⚠️ Problem-Focused vs. Emotion-Focused Coping: Students frequently mix these two up on the exam! Remember that _____ targets the root cause of the stress (actively trying to fix the actual problem), while _____ targets the feeling of stress (making yourself feel better internally when the problem cannot be easily or immediately fixed).

📺 *Video Notes: "Emotion, Stress, and Health" (Crash Course Psychology #26)*

This video covers more than today's topic. As your page notes, the part of the video about stress starts at about 4:52, so you can start watching there; the earlier sections on facial expressions and the basic emotions aren't part of this topic. Watch the video from about 4:52 on, then answer each question below in your own words.

1. How does the video define stress, why do appraisals matter, and what three categories of stressors does it name?

2. Why does the video say stress is natural and sometimes helpful, and which chemicals does it name?

3. What does the video say chronic stress does to the body, and how do the autonomic and enteric nervous systems explain digestive problems?

4. How does the video connect stress to heart disease, and what did the tax accountants study find?

5. What does the video say about pessimism, depression, and health, and what possible explanations does it give?

6. Quick Check: Review Questions

Circle the best answer for each question below.

1. Right before stepping on stage for a big dance recital, a performer feels a surge of nervous energy and adrenaline that actually sharpens her focus and helps her execute her routine flawlessly. This positive, motivating form of stress is called:

- **A.** Distress
- **B.** Tend and Befriend
- **C.** Eustress
- **D.** The Alarm Stage

2. A man who has endured years of chronic, unmanaged work stress is later diagnosed by his doctor with dangerously and chronically elevated blood pressure, significantly increasing his risk for a heart attack. This stress-related physical condition is called:

- **A.** Distress Exclusively
- **B.** Immune Suppression
- **C.** The Exhaustion Stage
- **D.** Hypertension

3. Weeks into an incredibly demanding new job with a difficult boss, a woman's body has adapted to the ongoing pressure and she continues to function and cope with her daily tasks, but she remains physiologically activated and on high alert the entire time. According to Selye, this ongoing coping phase is called the:

- **A.** Exhaustion Stage
- **B.** Alarm Stage
- **C.** Resistance Stage
- **D.** Eustress Stage

4. Rather than reacting to a stressful family crisis with a fight-or-flight response, a woman instead focuses her energy on comforting her children, checking in on her elderly neighbor, and calling close friends for emotional support. This alternative stress response, involving nurturing and connection, is called:

- **A.** Tend and Befriend
- **B.** The Alarm Stage
- **C.** Problem-Focused Coping
- **D.** Hypertension

5. Stuck at the airport with an unavoidable two-hour flight delay that she has no power to change, a woman puts on her headphones and listens to a calming playlist specifically to manage her own frustration and stay relaxed during the wait. This coping strategy, which targets the feeling of stress rather than the stressor itself, is called:

- **A.** Problem-Focused Coping
- **B.** Emotion-Focused Coping
- **C.** Tend and Befriend
- **D.** The Alarm Stage

6. A researcher studying childhood stress explains that experiences like abuse, neglect, or significant household dysfunction during a person's early years can act as significant sources of stress that affect that person throughout their entire lifespan. These potentially traumatic early-life events are called:

- **A.** Eustress
- **B.** Adverse Childhood Experiences (ACEs)
- **C.** The Resistance Stage
- **D.** Daily Hassles

✅ Check Your Progress

Done with your notes? Head over to the Quiz to test what you've learned:
https://appsychreviewhub.com/quiz

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